

DERIVATIONAL MORPHOLOGY

Building New Words and Expanding Vocabulary

How prefixes, roots, and suffixes work together to grow the English lexicon

Y Greeshma Reddy
192424146
B Tech-AI&DS

What Is Derivational Morphology?

The process of creating new words by attaching affixes to a base or root

KEY IDEA

Derivational morphemes are added to a root word to build an entirely new word — often shifting its meaning, its part of speech, or both.

EXAMPLE CHAIN

happy



happiness



unhappiness

DERIVATIONAL vs. INFLECTIONAL

D

Derivational

Creates a new word; often changes word class (kind → kindness)

I

Inflectional

Modifies the same word for grammar; class stays the same (walk → walked)

Both processes use affixes — but only derivation builds fresh vocabulary items.

Prefixes: Reshaping Meaning

Attached before the root — prefixes usually change meaning, not word class



not / opposite of

happy → unhappy



again / back

write → rewrite



wrongly

understand → misunderstand



before

view → preview

Prefixes rarely change a word's part of speech — they refine or reverse its meaning while the root stays grammatically the same.

Suffixes: Shifting Word Class

Attached after the root — suffixes often convert a word into a new part of speech



Noun

-tion, -ness, -ment

act → action



Verb

-ize, -ify, -en

active → activate



Adjective

-ful, -less, -able

care → careful



Adverb

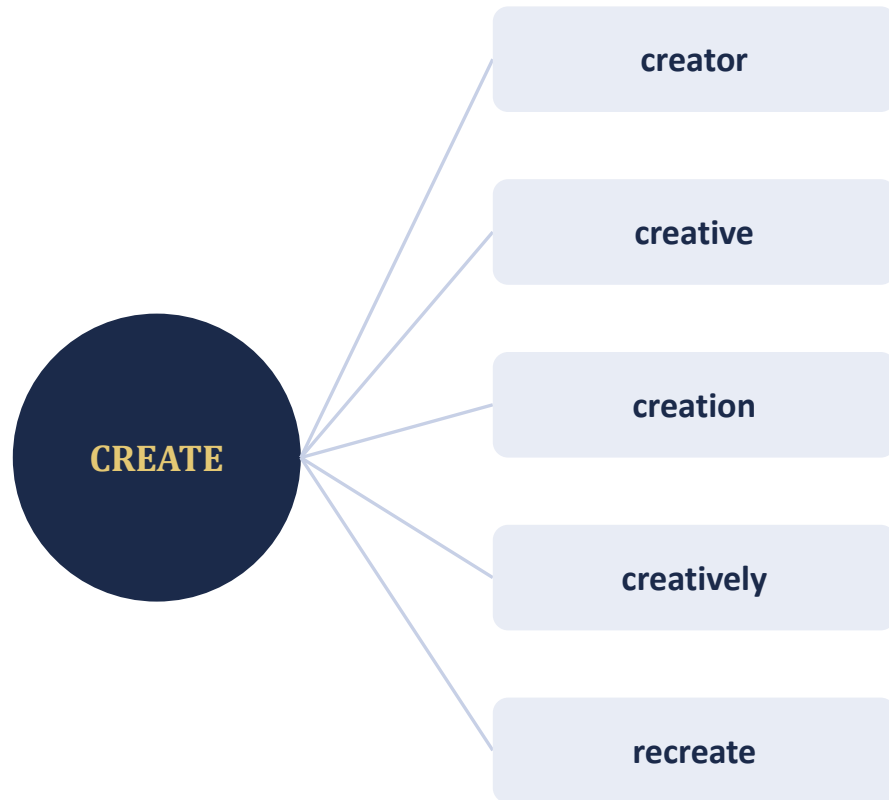
-ly

active → actively

One root, many classes: act → active (adj) → activate (verb) → activation (noun) → actively (adverb).

Expanding Vocabulary Through Word Families

One root, learned once, unlocks an entire family of related words



STRATEGIES FOR LEARNERS

- 1 Learn high-frequency roots and affixes rather than isolated words
- 2 Build word maps or family trees to connect new words to known ones
- 3 Practice sorting words by part of speech using suffix patterns
- 4 Use context to confirm meaning after decoding an unfamiliar affix

Conclusion

1

The engine of vocabulary growth

Derivational morphology turns a small set of roots and affixes into thousands of usable words.

2

A tool for decoding the unknown

Recognizing prefixes and suffixes lets learners infer meaning without a dictionary.

3

Efficient, transferable learning

Mastering common affix patterns builds vocabulary far faster than memorizing words one by one.

“Master the parts, and you unlock the whole lexicon.”